

PARROT-BEAKED HERBIVORE

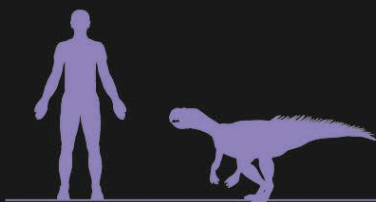
PSITTACOSAURUS

This small herbivore lived in the Cretaceous Period and is known from hundreds of fossils that show it had a narrow, parrotlike beak and small, sharp teeth that probably helped it slice into all kinds of vegetation. An exquisitely preserved specimen found in China shows evidence of a brown back and pale underbelly. This color pattern—with a darker back and lighter underside—helped *Psittacosaurus* camouflage itself in the dim light of its woody habitat. By studying fossilized pigments like these, paleontologists are able to work out the colors of dinosaurs.

**SUPER
CAMOUFLAGE**

AT A GLANCE

- **SIZE** 6½ ft (2 m) long
- **DIET** Herbivore
- **LIVED** 126–101 MYA
- **HABITAT** Damp woodlands



STATS AND FACTS

400
NUMBER OF FOSSILS FOUND

Using the large number of juvenile *Psittacosaurus* fossils that have been discovered, paleontologists have reconstructed this little herbivore's growth patterns. As a young *Psittacosaurus* matured, its skull shape changed, and after a few years, it began to walk upright on its hind legs.

HATCHLING SIZE



Psittacosaurus hatchlings measured 5 in (12 cm) in length and could find food for themselves without the help of adults.

WEIGHT



Psittacosaurus adults grew to 44 lb (20 kg), while youngsters have been estimated to weigh around 33 oz (940 g).

